

Guarantee Act, 2005, (MGNREGA), the allocation is announced at the time of the Budget because it's a demand-driven programme. We keep adding to it by raising the supplementary demand for grants. Before the Covid-19 pandemic, and also after the pandemic, there has never been a drop. However, if the focus is only on MGNREGA, you are missing out on several other items. Who are the ones building homes? There is a 66 per cent hike in Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana. Will the ₹79,000 crore spent there not benefit the same set of people? We have also given a higher allocation through our water programme, Jal Jeevan Mission. Building water tanks, taking piped water connections to the villages and from there to households, these tasks are now being performed by

MGNREGA workers. I would like to ask the Opposition to please spare some time to look at these initiatives and then come back to me.

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Udayan Mukherjee: *This ₹10 lakh-crore capex has to be lauded by everyone. But the sectors—roads, railways and defence—that you have targeted, do you think they have the capacity to absorb the number?*

Last year, while talking about the supplementary demand for grants in the Lok Sabha, I openly said that I am even giving ₹10,000 crore more for this year because the Indian Railways was moving ahead in terms of things that had been pending for decades. Also, with runways being built

in Tier II and III cities, civil aviation is growing in India. Similarly, the roads & highways sector has shown a capacity to absorb a higher allocation. For states, the ₹15,000-crore allocation in Budget 2021-22 was expanded to ₹1 lakh crore in Budget 2022-23. And now that has gone up to ₹1.3 lakh crore because states are showing a clear appetite to absorb more capital expenditure.

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Anjana Om Kashyap: *So, is it a populist Budget?*

No, it is a programme for the people. Several things kept languishing. It's not just about the centre's need to keep up the engagement with the states, which will happen anyway. It's also about addressing the collective aspirations of this nation.

